

Official Language

*Official language is mentioned in part-XVII (Art. 343-351) of the Indian constitution. *According to **Art. 343, the official language of the union shall be Hindi** in Devanagari script and the digits used for official purpose shall be an international form of Indian numerals. *According to Article 344, the president has the power to form a commission related to the official language. *The First official language commission under the chairmanship of **B.G. Kher** was constituted in 1955. *According to Art. 344 (4), there is a provision to form a 30- member joint parliament committee on official language. The committee consists of 20 members from Lok Sabha and 10 members from Rajya Sabha. *Any language can be added in the Indian constitution under the **8th Schedule**. *Initially only **14 languages** were added to the Indian constitution. ***'Sindhi'** language was added to the Indian constitution by 21st Constitutional Amendment Act, 1967. ***Konkani, Manipuri, Nepali** were added by **71st Constitutional Amendment Act 1992** in 8th schedule. *In **2003, Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and santhali** were added by **92nd Constitutional Amendment**. At present a total **22 languages** are there in 8th schedule. The state can choose any one Language as the official language. *There is a description of official language for communication between two states or between a state and the union in Article 346. *According to Article 347, there is a special provision relating to language spoken by a section of population of a state. *Hindi was declared as the official language on 14th September 1949. ***14 September** is celebrated as the **Hindi Diwas**. According to Article 348 (1) (a), all proceedings in the Supreme Court and every high court shall be done in English language. *According to **Article 350 A**, there is a provision of facilities for instruction in mother tongue at primary stage. Article 350B provides for the establishment of a special officer for linguistic minorities. The officer shall be appointed by president and shall investigate all matters relating to safeguards for linguistic minorities, reporting directly to the president.

1. The Constitution of India initially permitted the use of English language for all official purposes for a period of :

- (a) 10 years (b) 20 years

(c) 5 years

(d) 15 years

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre.) 2023

Ans. (d)

According to Article 343 clause (1) the official language of the Union shall be Hindi in Devanagari script. The form of numerals to be used for the official purposes of the Union shall be the international form of Indian numerals and according, to Article 343 clause (2), Notwithstanding anything in clause (1), for a period of fifteen years from the commencement of this Constitution, the English language shall continue to be used for all the official purposes of the Union for which it was being used immediately before such commencement.

2. Which Article of Indian Constitution provides the procedure for adoption of official Language or Languages of the State?

- (a) 343 (b) 344
(c) 345 (d) 346

R.A.S./R.T.S.(Pre) 2013

Ans. (c)

Article 345 of the Indian Constitution provides the procedure for the adoption of official language or languages of the State. According to this Article, subject to the provisions of Article 346 and 347, the Legislature of a State may, by law, adopt any one or more of the languages in use in the State or Hindi as the language or languages to be used for all or any of the official purposes of that State: Provided that, until the Legislature of the State otherwise provides by law, the English language shall continue to be used for those official purposes within the State for which it was being used immediately before the commencement of this Constitution. Article 343, provides for the official language of the Union. Article 344 deals with the commission and committee of parliament on official language. Article 346, provides for official language for communication between one State and another or between a State and the Union.

3. Parliament can amend the provision on official language of India under the Constitution by

- (a) a simple majority of its members
(b) 2/3rd majority
(c) 3/4th majority
(d) support of 1/3 of its members

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 2018

U.P.P.C.S. (Mains) 2005

Ans. (*)

There is a fundamental difference between the Hindi and English versions of the above question. In the Hindi format, the question has asked about the official language in the context of Constitution of India, whereas in the English format, the question focuses on the Parliament's authority of amending the official language of India. Hence, the nuances so present, create a contradictory nature among the intellects to resort to a conclusion.

*Part XVII of the constitution deals with the official language in Article 343 to 351. Its provisions are divided into four heads-

- a. Language of the Union
- b. Regional Languages
- c. Language of the Judiciary
- d. Texts of Laws and special directives

Thus it is quite evident from above context that the term 'The Official Language of India' is nowhere mentioned in the Indian constitution.

If we ignore the above mentioned 'mistake' or 'ambiguity' for the quiz, then it seems that the question relates to "the official language of the Union". As mentioned in the first paragraph of this interpretation, due to the difference between the Hindi and English forms of the question, the answer will also be different. According to Hindi form, option (b) is correct.

Amendment to Article 343, 344, 346 and 348 (1) (b) is possible only by the Parliament according to the overwhelming process mentioned in Article 368 (2), otherwise not. The amendment in above mentioned Articles i.e. 343, 344, 346 & 348 (1) does not require ratification of the state legislatures. On the other hand, if the English form of the question is accepted, then option (a) will be the correct answer.

According to article 343 (3) of constitution, Parliament is authorised for creating an exception to Article 343 (1). As per Article 100 (1), such a law will be made by Parliament with its simple majority. The Parliament has enacted the Official Language Act, 1963, using its power.

According to Section 3 of this Act, in addition to Hindi, English will also be used as the official language of the Union, from January 26, 1965. For some of the Union Government's purposes, English is mandatory. Clearly, any amendment in the said Act can be made by Parliament with its simple majority and accordingly, the official language of the Union can be amended according to the constitution. The word 'Provision' used in the English form of the question and the word 'Under the constitution' are being clarified in the article 343 (3) of the constitution.

Thus to elucidate there are two distinct answers to the same question.

4. Which one of the following is correct about the languages mentioned in the Constitution of India?

- (a) State can compel the linguistic minorities to choose their mother tongue as a medium of instruction in primary schools.

(b) 'Angika' is now included in the 8th Schedule of the Constitution.

(c) Hindi is National language of India.

(d) Bodo is a recognized language in the 8th Schedule of the Constitution.

U.P.P.C.S. (Mains) 2016

Ans. (d)

Bodo is a recognized language mentioned in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution. Bodo was included by 92nd Amendment Act, 2003 while other options are not correctly related to the languages mentioned in the Constitution of India. According to Article 343, Hindi is the official language of the Union not the national language of India.

5. Which Article of the Constitution provides that every state shall endeavour to provide an adequate facility for instruction in mother-tongue at primary stage of education?

(a) Article 349

(b) Article 350

(c) Article 350-A

(d) Article 351

U.P. P.C.S. (Pre) 2003

U.P. P.C.S. (Pre) 2002

U.P. Lower Sub. (Pre) 2002

I.A.S. (Pre) 2001

Ans. (c)

According to Article 350 A it shall be the endeavour of every State and every local authority within the State to provide adequate facilities for instruction in the mother-tongue at the primary stage of education to children belonging to linguistic minority groups; and the President may issue such directions to any State as he considers necessary or proper for securing the provision of such facilities (7th Amendment Act, 1956).

6. Under Article 344 of Indian Constitution, the first 'Official Language Commission' was established-

(a) In 1950 under the Chairmanship of K.M. Munshi

(b) In 1955 Under the Chairmanship of B.G. Kher

(c) In 1960 under the Chairmanship of M.C. Chagala

(d) In 1965 under the Chairmanship of Humayun Kabir

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 1998

Ans. (b)

According to Article 344 of the Indian Constitution, Dr. Rajendra Prasad appointed the First Official Language Commission under the chairmanship of B. G. Kher on 7 June, 1955. The Commission submitted its report in 1956. It recommended a number of steps to replace English with Hindi eventually. The Parliamentary Committee on Official Language, chaired by Govind Ballabh Pant was constituted in 1957 to review the Kher Commissions report.

7. Which of the following languages was added in the eighth schedule of the Constitution in 2003?

- (a) Konkani (b) Sindhi
(c) Manipuri (d) Santhali

Chhattisgarh P.C.S. (Pre) 2005

Ans. (d)

Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution recognizes 22 regional languages as the official language of the Union. Originally, there were only fourteen languages in this Schedule, the fifteenth language, Sindhi, was added by the 21st Constitution Amendment in 1967, and three languages, Konkani, Manipuri, and Nepali, were added by the 71st Amendment in August 1992. *Four more languages Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santhali, were added by the 92nd Amendment Act, 2003. *Thus, there are total 22 languages included in the eighth schedule: 1. Assamese 2. Bengali 3. Bodo 4. Dogri 5. Gujarati 6. Hindi 7. Kannada 8. Kashmiri 9. Malayalam 10. Maithili 11. Marathi 12. Oriya 13. Panjabi 14. Sanskrit 15. Sindhi 16. Tamil 17. Telugu 18. Santali 19. Urdu 20. Konkani 21. Manipuri and 22. Nepali.

8. In 1993 which of the following language was not included in the Eighth Schedule?

- (a) Maithili (b) Santhali
(c) Bodo (d) Dogri

U.P. R.O./A.R.O. (Pre) 2021

Ans. (*)

See the explanation of the above question.

9. Under which one of the following Constitutional Amendment Acts, four languages were added to the languages under the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution. Thereby raising their number to 22?

- (a) Constitution (90th Amendment) Act
(b) Constitution (91st Amendment) Act
(c) Constitution (92nd Amendment) Act
(d) Constitution (93rd Amendment) Act

I.A.S. (Pre) 2007

Ans. (c)

See the explanation of the above question.

10. Which of the following languages is not included in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution?

- (a) Urdu (b) Nepali
(c) Konkani (d) Bhojpur

M.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 2005

Ans. (d)

See the explanation of the above question.

11. Which of the following languages has been added to Eighth Schedule by Constitutional Amendment?

- (a) Sanskrit (b) Sindhi
(c) Punjabi (d) Konkani

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 1990

Ans. (b) & (d)

See the explanation of the above question.

12. Which of the following is not included in Eighth Schedule of our Constitution?

- (a) Gujrati (b) Kashmiri
(c) Rajasthani (d) Dogri

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 1993

Ans. (c)

See the explanation of the above question.

13. The Constitution (71st Amendment) Act, 1992 amends the Eighth Schedule to the Constitution to include which of the following languages?

1. Konkani 2. Manipuri
3. Nepali 4. Maithili

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 (b) 1, 2 and 4
(c) 1, 3 and 4 (d) 2, 3 and 4

I.A.S. (Pre) 2024

Ans. (a)

The Eighth Schedule to the Constitution consists of the following 22 languages: (1) Assamese, (2) Bengali, (3) Gujarati, (4) Hindi, (5) Kannada, (6) Kashmiri, (7) Konkani, (8) Malayalam, (9) Manipuri, (10) Marathi, (11) Nepali, (12) Odia, (13) Punjabi, (14) Sanskrit, (15) Sindhi, (16) Tamil, (17) Telugu, (18) Urdu, (19) Bodo, (20) Santhali, (21) Maithili and (22) Dogri.

Of these languages, 14 were initially included in the Constitution. Sindhi language was added in 1967 through the Constitution (21st Amendment) Act, 1967. Thereafter three more languages viz., Konkani, Manipuri and Nepali were included in 1992 by the Constitution (71st Amendment) Act, 1992. Subsequently Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santhali were added in 2004 by the Constitution (92nd Amendment) Act, 2003. Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.

14. Which three languages have been added to the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution by 71st Amendment?

- (a) Sindhi, Manipuri, Konkani
(b) Konkani, Kashmiri, Nepali
(c) Nepali, Konkani, Manipuri
(d) Nepali, Konkani, Assamese

M.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 1993

Ans. (c)

See the explanation of the above question.

15. Which of the language is not included in the VIII Schedule of the constitution?

- (a) English (b) Hindi
(c) Sanskrit (d) Urdu

Chhattisgarh P.C.S. (Pre) 2018

Ans. (a)

Languages recognised by the constitution are included in Eighth (VIII) Schedule. Initially, it had 14 languages, but presently there are 22 languages. Of these 22 languages, English is not one of them, so option a is correct.

16. The number of official languages recognised by the constitution in the eight schedule is.....

- (a) 16 (b) 17
(c) 18 (d) 20

48th to 52nd B.P.S.C. (Pre) 2008

Uttarakhand P.C.S. (Mains) 2006

U.P.P.C.S. (Spl) (Mains) 2004

Ans. (*)

Before 92nd Constitution Amendment Act, 2003 there were total 18 languages in the Eight Schedule of the Constitution which increased to 22 after 92nd Constitution Amendment Act.

17. The number of official languages recognized under Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution is –

- (a) 22 (b) 20
(c) 18 (d) 17

U.P.P.C.S. (GIC) 2010

Ans. (a)

See the explanation of the above question.

18. Which of the following states has given the Sanskrit language the status of second official language?

- (a) Bihar (b) Chhattisgarh
(c) Uttar Pradesh (d) Uttarakhand

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 2011

Ans. (d)

The State of Uttarakhand on January 1, 2010 gave the Sanskrit language the status of the second official language. After some time, former Chief Minister, Ramesh Pokhriyal 'Nishank' declared 'Rishikesh' as Sanskrit city.

19. Which one of the following languages included in the VIII Schedule of the Constitution is spoken by the largest number of people?

- (a) Bengali (b) Gujarati
(c) Marathi (d) Telugu

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 1998 (*)

Ans. (a)

According to the Census-2001 data and Census-1991 data, Bengali is the language spoken by the largest number of persons (in India) among the given options. Telugu is at the second rank. According to the census, 2011 data, Hindi is the Language spoken by the largest number of persons (in India). Bengali is at the second and Marathi is third.

20. Which of the following is the correct sequence in descending order of the Indian languages, being used as mother tongue?

1. Bengali 2. Marathi
3. Tamil 4. Telugu

Select correct answer using the code given below:

Code :

- (a) 1, 4, 3, 2 (b) 1, 2, 4, 3
(c) 1, 4, 2, 3 (d) 4, 2, 1, 3

U.P.P.C.S. (Pre) 2001 (*)

Ans. (c)

According to the Census data-2001 the descending order of the Indian languages are: Bengali (8.11%) > Telugu (7.19%) > Marathi (6.99%) > Tamil (5.91%). According to the Census data - 2011, the descending order of the Indian Languages are : Hindi (43.63%) > Bengali (8.03%) > Marathi (6.86%) > Telugu (6.70%) > Tamil (5.70%).

21. Percentage of Hindi speaking Indians is about :

- (a) 50 (b) 45
(c) 40 (d) 35

R.A.S./R.T.S.(Pre) 2003 (*)

Ans. (*)

According to the Census-2001 data, the percentage of Hindi speaking Indians was maximum. It was 41.03% as per 2001 census and 43.63% as per 2011 census.

22. In context to Constitution of India which statement is correct?

- (a) Article 243(A) – Constitution of Panchayats
(b) Article 243(B) – Gram Sabha
(c) Article 243(C) – Composition of Panchayat
(d) None of the above

Chhattisgarh P.C.S. (Pre) 2024

Ans. (c)

Article 243(A) – Gram Sabha
Article 243(B) – Constitution of Panchayats
Article 243(C) – Composition of Panchayat
In this way the pair in option (c) is correct.
Note : The Question mentions Article 243(A), 243(B) and 243(C), Whereas it should be Article 243A, 243B and 243C. Actually,
243(a) – Definition of 'District'